

PURITY, ACTIVITY, VIGILANCE, AND DISCRETION

THE METROPOLITAN POLICE ACT (1829)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Law enforcement

BEFORE

1666 King Louis XIV of France creates the first system of policing in Paris.

1749 London's first salaried police, the Bow Street Runners, form to tackle high crime rates.

1786 The Dublin Police Act creates a uniformed, metropolitan police force in Dublin, Ireland.

AFTER

1835 The Municipal Corporations Act requires each British local council to appoint a paid constable to keep the peace.

1878 The UK's Criminal Investigation Department (CID) starts up, with more emphasis on solving crimes.

1919 Sofia Stanley is the Metropolitan Police's first female recruit.

The ancient Egyptians, Greeks, and Romans all had a loose form of policing for maintaining public order and keeping watch at night. In medieval England, the Anglo-Saxons took this idea further with the Statute of Winchester in 1285, which directed all citizens to keep the king's peace, making policing a collective responsibility. These and other early forms of policing did not extend to investigating or prosecuting crimes, such as theft or assault, which were considered to be private matters between individuals.